Bhugarbha Gosvami

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The Eighth Gosvami

Among the Vaishnavas of Vrindavana who saw the first decades after Mahaprabhu's disappearance, two elders were held in special honour — Lokanatha and Bhugarbha. The Gaudiya community of that time called them the seventh and eighth Gosvamis, after the six Gosvamis of Vrindavana, and to this day they are worshipped just as the six are. They were counted among the foremost Gosvamis of Vraja also because they were senior to many in years and experience: they came to Vraja before Rupa and Sanatana and were older even than Jiva.

Little is known of Bhugarbha, and the essential was said of him by Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami in a single line of the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”:

“And the disciple of Gadadhara Pandita named Bhugarbha Gosvami likewise spoke only of the deeds of Sri Chaitanya. Other subjects held no interest for him at all.” (CC, Adi 8.68)

Gaura-katha — talk of Gaura — was the whole of his speech: he spoke of nothing else and spent all his days in conversation about the Lord.

Disciple of Gadadhara Pandita

Bhugarbha was a disciple of Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami and received initiation from him; for this reason he is placed in Gadadhara's branch of the Chaitanya tree. There Krishnadasa Kaviraja names him together with Bhagavata Dasa:

“Bhugarbha Gosvami and Bhagavata Dasa came to Vrindavana and lived there all their lives.” (CC, Adi 12.82)[1]

In the list of Gadadhara's branches they come eleventh and twelfth.

Bhagavata Dasa was his fellow disciple under Gadadhara and his close friend. The “Shakha-nirnaya” bows in its thirty-first verse to Bhagavata Dasa as “Bhugarbha's companion,” whose mind is ever adorned with songs of the pastimes of Radha and Krishna.

To Bhugarbha himself the same book gives a verse of homage of his own. It praises him as an ever-magnanimous master who bestows love for Krishna, merciful and pure, finding his happiness in the service of Sri Govindadeva — bliss itself in person. The verse also plays on his name: “bhu-garbha” means “the womb of the earth,” and Bhugarbha is called “one risen from the depths of the earth.”[2]

Where he was born and who his parents were, the biographies do not say. According to the “Sadhana-dipika,” he was Lokanatha's paternal uncle.[3]

Inseparable from Lokanatha

All of Bhugarbha's life that we know of was spent beside Lokanatha Gosvami. They were eternal friends, men “of one heart”; Bhugarbha was Lokanatha's closest friend and constant companion. Narahari Chakravarti writes of Lokanatha in the “Bhakti-ratnakara”:

“His affection for Bhugarbha is known to the world: only their bodies were different from Lokanatha's.” (BR 1.317)

And in the sixth wave of the same book Bhugarbha and Lokanatha are called together a mine of virtues.

Their bond is one example of how the Lord's associates chose their companions. Sanatana, Rupa and Raghunatha; Lokanatha and Bhugarbha; later Narottama and Ramachandra Kaviraja — each of these bonds had its own style of bhajana, yet they chose one another without a trace of rivalry or envy. This does not mean they lived under one roof: what united them was the love of kindred souls, and that love itself served the following of Vrishabhanu's daughter and delighted Radhanatha. Of dividing into parties they never even thought.

The Road to Vraja

Lokanatha and Bhugarbha came to live in Vraja at Mahaprabhu's command, even before Rupa and Sanatana; they were the first of Chaitanya's devotees to leave for Vrindavana. Lokanatha was the first Gaudiya Vaishnava whom the Lord told to go there, and he went together with Bhugarbha.

And this is how Bhugarbha came to be Lokanatha's companion. When Lokanatha in Navadvipa was taking leave of the Lord, weeping and clasping His feet, Gadadhara Pandita stood nearby with his disciple Bhugarbha. Bhugarbha's heart melted at the scene: he would not let his friend go alone and offered to go with him himself. He asked leave of his guru; the Lord glanced at Gadadhara approvingly, and Gadadhara gladly let his disciple go.[4] According to one biography, Lokanatha left home and came to the Lord in Navadvipa in 1510 (1431 of the Shaka era).

They walked for about two months, without a single coin, living on alms. At Rajmahal, on the border of Bengal, they first heard a foreign tongue and met the indifference of the inhabitants. Beyond lay Tejpur, Purnia, Ayodhya, Lucknow, Agra and, at last, Gokula and Vrindavana.[5] Attachment to parents, to home, to comforts and to their native land — all this the two, still young men, had left behind.

Vraja met them with dense jungle and thickets where beasts of prey roamed. Of the former beauty of its temples and Deities no trace remained; the local people had forgotten the holy places and their history, and only the Yamuna and Govardhana remained as witnesses of the past. The foreign language was a hindrance too. They could not find Chira-ghata with its kadamba grove, where the Lord had told Lokanatha to perform bhajana — nor Vamshivata, nor Shyama-kunda, nor Radha-kunda.

Then they began to call aloud, “Radha! Krishna!” and went calling so through all the countryside. Now weeping, now laughing, as if mad, they fell at the feet of the Vrajavasis asking where Krishna could be found; they rolled on the ground and smeared their heads and eyes with the dust of Vraja, saying that it purifies the heart.

Searching for the Lord, and Chira-ghata

Meanwhile the Lord took sannyasa and went to the South, where He travelled for two years, and then came to Vrindavana.[6] Hearing of His journey south, Lokanatha and Bhugarbha — Lokanatha above all, in great anxiety — went south to find Him. So it happened that for the whole two months the Lord spent in Vrindavana they were not there.[7]

When they returned, the Lord consoled Lokanatha in a dream. Seeing Him in the dress of a sannyasi, He said, they would only grieve; let them rather meditate on His former form — with its beautiful curls.

Soon the friends found Chira-ghata with its grove and stayed there for the rest of their lives. Day and night they sang the names of Krishna, leaving only an hour or two for rest and sleep, kept far from people and never left their bhajana.

Solitary Bhajana

Both Lokanatha and Bhugarbha displayed the pastime of the most secluded devotees, whose bliss lies in bhajana (maha-vivikta bhajanandi), and both loved the pastimes of Gaura.

His bhajana was bound up with Sri Govindadeva. The “Vartika-prakasha” — a Hindi commentary on Nabhaji's “Bhakta-mala” — gives Bhugarbha a few lines. Holding firmly to the dhama, it says, he lived in Vrindavana, in the incomparable temple-kunja of Sri Govinda, and his happiness was the love of Sri Govindadeva. He was deeply detached from the world, wholeheartedly attached to the sweetness of the Lord's form — the form of Sri Govinda — and relished it in the company of the best devotees. His food and life was mental service — manasi-seva through all eight periods of the day (ashtakaliya), and with his inner eye he unceasingly beheld the united form of Gaura and Shyama.

His inner state, the “Vartika-prakasha” goes on, is beyond the ordinary mind. His heart was full of the fathomless rasa of divine love, and only saints who know rasa — the best of sadhus — understood him. So the whole of Bhugarbha's hidden life remains a mystery to the ordinary mind.

In Rupa's Circle

Bhugarbha came to Vraja before Rupa Gosvami, yet in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” he is named in Rupa's circle. On the pretext of fear of the mlecchas, Gopala came from Govardhana to Mathura, to the house of Vitthalanatha, the son of Vallabhacharya — and in truth showed by this His mercy to the aged Rupa. For a whole month Rupa stayed in Mathura beholding Him, and with him were his companions:

“Sri Rupa with his companions also spent a whole month in Mathura beholding this Deity. He was accompanied by Gopala Bhatta Gosvami, Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami, Raghunatha Bhatta Gosvami and Lokanatha Dasa Gosvami. Bhugarbha Gosvami, Sri Jiva Gosvami, Sri Yadava Acharya and Govinda Gosvami.” (CC, Madhya 18.48–50)

That month Bhugarbha not only beheld Gopaladeva but danced and sang before Him.[8]

Disciples and the “Chaitanya-charitamrita”

Krishnadasa Kaviraja names Bhugarbha's disciples as well:

“The disciples of Bhugarbha Gosvami were Chaitanya Dasa (the servant of the Deity Govinda), Mukundananda Chakravarti and Krishnadasa, full of divine love.” (CC, Adi 8.69)

He had other disciples too, and each of them, in the words of one biography, was a maha-bhagavata; all of them ever thirsted to drink the nectar of Gaura's pastimes. Chaitanya Dasa, already in the days of Kaviraja Gosvami, was a wholly devoted, beloved servant of Govindadeva.

Bhugarbha and his disciples were among those Vaishnavas of Vrindavana who wished to hear of Gaura's last pastimes, which Vrindavana Dasa had left undescribed in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata.” In listing them, Kaviraja names Bhugarbha and his disciples especially, and then says:

“And many other great Vaishnavas of Sri Vrindavana-dhama also wished to hear of the concluding pastimes of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. All these Vaishnavas bestowed their mercy on me. Therefore, casting off all shame, I have undertaken to write of the pastimes of Sri Chaitanya, humbly carrying out their direct instructions.” (CC, Adi 8.71–72)

It was with the permission and blessing of Bhugarbha and Lokanatha that Krishnadasa Kaviraja began to write of Mahaprabhu's last pastimes.

But these elders themselves — Lokanatha, Bhugarbha and others — told Kaviraja not to mention them in the book; that is why so little about them has survived.[9] Vrindavana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” likewise names neither Lokanatha nor Bhugarbha — perhaps for the same reason. There is no ill will in this: the chroniclers of the Lord's pastimes sometimes leave part of the story to those who come after.

In this prohibition lies a lesson for all. As long as even a shadow of the desire for fame remains in the heart, hari-bhajana is impossible. Even mayavadis can give up women and wealth, but the thirst for worldly prestige is the worst enemy of love for Krishna. That is why Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami, in the “Manah-shiksha” and at the beginning of the “Vraja-vilasa-stava” and other hymns, condemns it more than anything else.

Why “Six”

If Lokanatha and Bhugarbha were older and came to Vraja earlier, why are the Gosvamis called six and not eight? Sanatana, Rupa and the others displayed the pastime of acharyas: they wrote books and preached. Raghunatha Bhatta wrote no works, but he was an acharya as an expounder of the “Bhagavata”: in Rupa's assembly he read the “Srimad-Bhagavatam,” overflowing with love, and later had a disciple build a temple for Govinda and himself made ornaments for Him (CC, Antya 13.126, 131). Lokanatha and Bhugarbha, however, displayed a different pastime — that of secluded bhajanandis — and so were not counted among the six.

An Elder of Vrindavana

After the Lord's disappearance Bhugarbha remained one of the elders of the Vrindavana community. When Srinivasa came to Vrindavana, Jiva Gosvami introduced him to Lokanatha, Bhugarbha Gosvami, Paramananda and Madhu Pandita. Later, when Srinivasa was to carry the Gosvamis' books to Gauda — the departure was fixed for the shukla-panchami of the month of Agrahayana — at Jiva's word he received the order and blessing of Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha, Lokanatha, Madhu Pandita and others. Thus Bhugarbha, together with Lokanatha, Gopala Bhatta, Raghunatha Dasa and Krishnadasa Kaviraja, blessed Srinivasa, Narottama and Shyamananda on their way to Bengal with the books.

The second time, Srinivasa came to Vrindavana in grief: in Gauda Shuklambara, Gadadhara Dasa and Narahari had departed. He saw Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha and Lokanatha and heard from them stories of Gaura and Krishna; together with Jiva they encouraged him and eased his sorrow.

When Jahnava Devi came to Vraja, the heads of the Vaishnava community — Jiva, Gopala Bhatta, Lokanatha, Bhugarbha, Madhu Pandita — came out to honour her.[10] With the permission and blessing of Bhugarbha and Jiva, Virachandra (Virabhadra) too went round Vraja: the twelve forests, Radha-kunda and Shyama-kunda, Govardhana.[11]

Ramachandra Kaviraja, coming to Vrindavana, was granted the darshana of the feet of Gopala Bhatta, Lokanatha and Bhugarbha and received their mercy and blessing.[12]

Narottama Thakura was in close and loving association with Bhugarbha. In a humble song of his “Prarthana” he laments that he did not serve the feet of the Gosvamis without whose mercy he cannot attain the service of Radha and Krishna in Vraja, and among them he names Bhugarbha. There are nine such Gosvamis in the song: Svarupa, Sanatana, Rupa, Raghunatha, the two Bhattas, Bhugarbha, Jiva and Lokanatha.[13]

Departure

Bhugarbha Gosvami left this world in Vrindavana, in the lifetime of Jiva Gosvami. Jiva informed Srinivasa of it in a letter. The “Prema-vilasa” renders his words thus:

“But the feet of Sri Bhugarbha Gosvami — he has left his body, giving himself to Krishna; and this in particular: it took place in full awareness.” (“Prema-vilasa,” 25.21–22)

The day of his departure is the shukla-chaturdashi of the month of Kartika.[14] By our calendar it is observed on Gaura-chaturdashi of the month of Damodara, on the same day as Kashishvara Pandita. Where his samadhi is, the biographies do not say.

Prema-manjari

Who Bhugarbha is in Krishna's eternal pastimes is revealed by Kavi Karnapura in the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika":

"The former name of Bhugarbha Thakura is Prema-manjari; Lokanatha Gosvami is the former Sri Lila-manjari." (GGD 187)

In Vraja he is Prema-manjari, one of the manjaris, the maidservants of Srimati Radharani, and in the same verse his inseparable friend is named beside him.[15]

So in one name his whole life comes together: he who spoke of nothing but Gaura and gave all his time to the mental service of Radha and Krishna is himself, in Vraja, Prema-manjari — "the bud of love" in Radha's service. His blessing stands at the source of the "Chaitanya-charitamrita," and the humility with which he forbade anyone to write of him has remained a lesson for all who walk the path of bhajana.

1. In the Bengali numbering followed by the biographies this is Adi 12.81; in one of them the reference is wrongly given as 2.12.81 (that is, Madhya-lila).

2. These words are explained differently: according to one biography, they mean that he is beyond the mortal world; according to another, that he was, as people say, born from the depths of the earth.

3. Only one biography reports this; the others say nothing of kinship.

4. According to another biography, Bhugarbha decided to go with Lokanatha on seeing his grief; Gadadhara and his permission are not mentioned there. According to a third, Lokanatha wandered the holy places alone, came to Vrindavana, and only there met Rupa, Sanatana, Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha and others — although the same biography says elsewhere that both came to Vrindavana at the Lord's command.

5. Another biography gives a shorter route: Rajmahal, Tajpur, Purnia, Lucknow and many holy places.

6. One biography adds that the Lord had sent Rupa and Sanatana to Vrindavana before this. According to the "Chaitanya-charitamrita," He sent them there only after His own stay in Vraja: Rupa from Prayaga (Madhya 19.240), Sanatana from Kashi (Madhya 25.175).

7. Only one biography says that Bhugarbha went south together with Lokanatha and that in the dream the Lord addressed them both; the other two tell of the search for the Lord and of the dream with reference to Lokanatha alone.

8. One of the biographies, telling of this month in Mathura, names Lokanatha and "other Gaudiya Vaishnavas" but does not mention Bhugarbha.

9. According to one of the biographies, it was Lokanatha alone who gave this instruction.

10. According to another biography, some of the Vaishnavas of Vraja, Bhugarbha among them, met Jahnava already in Mathura.

11. According to one biography — with the blessing, according to another — at the command of Bhugarbha and Jiva.

12. According to one of the biographies, these senior Gosvamis — Lokanatha, Gopala Bhatta and Bhugarbha — also gave him the title "Kaviraja"; according to another, the title was given by Jiva Gosvami.

13. In the retelling of one biography Rupa is not named in this list: it has eight names — Svarupa Damodara, Sanatana, Raghunatha Bhatta, Raghunatha Dasa, Gopala Bhatta, Bhugarbha, Jiva and Lokanatha.

14. Only one biography gives this date; the other two do not name the day of his departure.

15. According to the "Prema-vilasa" (7.268–269), Bhugarbha in Vraja is Nandimukhi, who tenderly loves Manjulali (Lokanatha); this testimony carries less authority than the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika."